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SPECIAL REPORT OF THE USAF SCIENTIFIC ADVISORY BOARD AD HOC COMMITTEE TO REVIEW PROJECT "BLUE BOOK"

MARCH 1966

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SPECIAL
REPORT OF THE
USAF SCIENTIFIC ADVISORY BOARD
AD HOC COMMITTEE TO REVIEW
PROJECT "BLUE BOOK"

MARCH 1966

MEMBERS PARTICIPATING

Dr. Brian O'Brien (Chairman)
Dr. Launor F. Carter
Mr. Jesse Orlansky
Dr. Richard Porter
Dr. Carl Sagan
Dr. Willis H. Ware

SAB SECRETARIAT

Lt Col Harold A. Steiner

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

		Page
I.	Introduction	1
II.	Discussion	1
III.	Conclusions and Recommendations	2
TAB A -	Memorandum from Major General LeBailly	6
TAB B -	Agenda	8
Distribution		9

SPECIAL
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I. INTRODUCTION

As requested in a memorandum from Major General E. B. LeBailly, Secretary of the Air Force Office of Information, dated 28 September 1965 (Tab A), an SAB Ad Hoc Committee met on 3 February 1966 to review Project "Blue Book". The objectives of the Committee are to review the resources and methods of investigation prescribed by Project "Blue Book" and to advise the Air Force of any improvements that can be made in the program to enhance the Air Force's capability in carrying out its responsibility.

In order to bring themselves up to date, the members of the Committee initially reviewed the findings of previous scientific panels charged with looking into the UFO problem. Particular attention was given to the report of the Robertson panel which was rendered in January 1953. The Committee next heard briefings from the AFSC Foreign Technology Division, which is the cognizant Air Force agency that collates information on UFO sightings and monitors investigations of individual cases. Finally, the Committee reviewed selected case histories of UFO sightings with particular emphasis on those that have not been identified.

II. DISCUSSION

Although about 6% (646) of all sightings (10,147) in the years 1947 through 1965 are listed by the Air Force as "Unidentified", it appears to the Committee that

most of the cases so listed are simply those in which the information available does not provide an adequate basis for analysis. In this connection it is important also to note that no unidentified objects other than those of an astronomical nature have ever been observed during routine astronomical studies, in spite of the large number of observing hours which have been devoted to the sky. As examples of this the Palomar Observatory Sky Atlas contains some 5000 plates made with large instruments with wide field of view; the Harvard Meteor Project of 1954-1958 provided some 3300 hours of observation; the Smithsonian Visual Prairie Network provided 2500 observing hours. Not a single unidentified object has been reported as appearing on any of these plates or been sighted visually in all these observations.

The Committee concluded that in the 19 years since the first UFO was sighted there has been no evidence that unidentified flying objects are a threat to our national security. Having arrived at this conclusion the Committee then turned its attention to considering how the Air Force should handle the scientific aspects of the UFO problem. Unavoidably these are also related to Air Force public relations, a subject on which the Committee is not expert. Thus the recommendations which follow are made simply from the scientific point of view.

III. CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

It is the opinion of the Committee that the present Air Force program dealing with UFO sightings has been well organized, although the resources assigned to it (only one officer, a sergeant, and secretary) have been quite limited. In 19 years and more than 10,000 sightings recorded and classified, there appears to be no verified and fully satisfactory evidence of any case that is clearly outside the framework of presently

known science and technology. Nevertheless, there is always the possibility that analysis of new sightings may provide some additions to scientific knowledge of value to the Air Force. Moreover, some of the case records which the Committee looked that were listed as "identified" were sightings where the evidence collected was too meager or too indefinite to permit positive listing in the identified category. Because of this the Committee recommends that the present program be strengthened to provide opportunity for scientific investigation of selected sightings in more detail and depth than has been possible to date.

To accomplish this it is recommended that:

A. Contracts be negotiated with a few selected universities to provide scientific teams to investigate promptly and in depth certain selected sightings of UFO's. Each team should include at least one psychologist, preferably one interested in clinical psychology, and at least one physical scientist, preferably an astronomer or geophysicist familiar with atmospheric physics. The universities should be chosen to provide good geographical distribution, and should be within convenient distance of a base of the Air Force Systems Command (AFSC).

B. At each AFSC base an officer skilled in investigation (but not necessarily with scientific training) should be designated to work with the corresponding university team for that geographical section. The local representative of the Air Force Office of Special Investigations (OSI) might be a logical choice for this.

C. One university or one not-for-profit organization should be selected to coordinate the work of the teams mentioned under A above, and also to make certain of very close communication and coordination with the office of Project Blue Book.

It is thought that perhaps 100 sightings a year might be subjected to this close study, and that possibly an average of 10 man days might be required per sighting so studied. The information provided by such a program might bring to light new facts of scientific value, and would almost certainly provide a far better basis than we have today for decision on a long term UFO program.

The scientific reports on these selected sightings, supplementing the present program of the Project Blue Book office, should strengthen the public position of the Air Force on UFO's. It is, therefore, recommended that:

A. These reports be printed in full and be available on request.

B. Suitable abstracts or condensed versions be printed and included in, or as supplements to, the published reports of Project Blue Book.

C. The form of report (as typified by "Project Blue Book" dated 1 February 1966) be expanded, and anything which might suggest that information is being withheld (such as the wording on page 5 of the above cited reference) be deleted. The form of this report can be of great importance in securing public understanding and should be given detailed study by an appropriate Air Force office.

D. The reports "Project Blue Book" should be given wide unsolicited circulation among prominent members of the Congress and other public persons as a further aid to public understanding of the scientific approach being taken by the Air Force in attacking the UFO problem.

DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE
WASHINGTON

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY

SEP 28 1965

MEMORANDUM FOR MILITARY DIRECTOR, SCIENTIFIC ADVISORY BOARD

SUBJECT: Unidentified Flying Objects (UFOs)

In keeping with its air defense role, the Air Force has the responsibility for the investigation of unidentified flying objects reported over the United States. The name of this project is Blue Book (Attachment 1). Procedures for conducting this program are established by Air Force Regulation 200-2 (Attachment 2).

The Air Force has conducted Project Blue Book since 1948. As of 30 June 1965, a total of 9267 reports had been investigated by the Air Force. Of these 9267 reports, 663 cannot be explained.

It has been determined by the Assistant Deputy Chief of Staff/ Plans and Operations that Project Blue Book is a worthwhile program which deserves the support of all staff agencies and major commands and that the Air Force should continue to investigate and analyze all UFO reports in order to assure that such objects do not present a threat to our national security. The Assistant Deputy Chief of Staff/Plans and Operations has determined also that the Foreign Technology Division (FTD) at Wright-Patterson Air Force Base should continue to exercise its presently assigned responsibilities concerning UFOs.

To date, the Air Force has found no evidence that any of the UFO reports reflect a threat to our national security. However, many of the reports that cannot be explained have come from intelligent and technically well qualified individuals whose integrity cannot be doubted. In addition, the reports received officially by the Air Force include only a fraction of the spectacular reports which are publicized by many private UFO organizations.

Accordingly, it is requested that a working scientific panel composed of both physical and social scientists be organized to review Project Blue Book -- its resources, methods, and findings -- and to advise the Air Force as to any improvements that should be made in the program in order to carry out the Air Force's assigned responsibility.

Doctor J. Allen Hynek who is the Chairman of the Dearborn Observatory at Northwestern University is the scientific consultant to Project Blue Book. He has indicated a willingness to work with such a panel in order to place this problem in its proper perspective.

Doctor Hynek has discussed this problem with Doctor Winston R. Markey, the former Air Force Chief Scientist.

E. B. LeBAILLY
Major General, USAF
Director of Information

2 Attachments
1. Blue Book Report
2. AFR 200-2

AD HOC COMMITTEE ON
UNIDENTIFIED FLYING OBJECTS (UFOs)

AGENDA

Thursday, 3 February 1966

0800	Welcoming Remarks	Commander or Vice Commander, FTD
0805	Introduction	Dr. O'Brien, SAB
0810	The Air Force Problem	Lt Col Spaulding, SAFOI
0830	Briefing on Project Blue Book	Major Quintanilla, FTD
1000	Break	
1015	Review of Selected Case Histories	FTD Staff
1145	Lunch	
1315	Executive and Writing Session	

22 December 1965

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DISTRIBUTION

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Secretary of the Air Force Office of Information	SAFOI	25
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Commander, Foreign Technology Division		5
DCS/Foreign Technology (AFSC)	SCF	2
Chairman, SAB	AFBSA	1
SAB Secretariat	AFBSA	1

Meeting statistics bearing on this report including all times, dates, places, a listing of persons in attendance and purposes therefor, together with their affiliations and material reviewed and discussed, are available in the SAB Secretariat offices for review by authorized persons or agencies.

APPROVED BY:

Harold A. Steiner

HAROLD A. STEINER, Lt Colonel, USAF
Assistant Secretary
USAF Scientific Advisory Board